leader best suited to lead a coalition against the BJP. Simultaneously, he too exhibited clear national ambitions, with AAP's expansionist moves beyond Delhi—contesting in Punjab, Goa, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Gujarat. The modest returns elsewhere were offset first with AAP's spectacular success in Punjab, and then a 12 per cent vote share in Gujarat earned it the status of a national party. On cue, Kejriwal had begun fraternising with other regional parties, with the attendant talk of a 'third front'.

Sisodia's arrest may bring a halt to this exercise for now. As its immediate backdrop, AAP-ruled Punjab also witnessed a collapse of law and order, with state police giving in to protesters and releasing a key aide of Sikh radical leader Amritpal Singh Sandhu from jail. The party lost a bit of its sheen

KEJRIWAL PROJECTED HIMSELF AS THE ONLY NON-CONGRESS ALTERNATIVE TO THE BJP. THIS MAY TAKE A SEVERE HIT NOW

as the incident strengthened rivals' charges that the AAP government has lost its grip over a key frontier state, even while Kejriwal remote-controls its administration from Delhi. Before that, many party leaders felt Jain's arrest had derailed their campaign in Himachal.

Analysts are not writing off Kejriwal. For now, AAP is playing the victim card. If his ministers manage bail soon, Kejriwal will project that as a vindication of his stand. He has his campaign line ready: that the BJP jailed the two ministers who gave people affordable healthcare and education. If the legal trail forks out differently, the CM will have a practical problem to solve first. It will be difficult to find a replacement for Sisodia, who not only looked after the daily administration of Delhi, leaving Kejriwal free to focus on politics, but also stood by him all these years. ■

CONGRESS PLENARY

THE CONGRESS HAND AS A FIST

By Kaushik Deka

"Crores of workers of the Congress party must build on the momentum of the Bharat Jodo Yatra to defeat the divisive forces of the BJP and RSS. A mass awareness campaign will be launched against the crudest example of crony capitalism which the entire country and the world is seeing." The concluding sentences of this 'Call to Action' document revealed a new glint of steel in the Grand Old Party's campaign plan for the 2024 general election. Released on the concluding day of the Congress's 85th plenary session, held in Raipur over February 24-26, the document incorporates a four-pronged strategy. Chief among them is the idea of harnessing the energy created by Rahul Gandhi's cross-country yatra. This bleeds over into the other three: trying to win six assembly polls later this year on its own steam; showcasing the governance model of Congress-ruled states, built around a vision of social justice and inclusivity; and tapping into that momentum to build an alliance of like-minded Opposition parties with the Congress at its centre.

All good in theory, critics could say, till they try to put it into practice. But a new self-confidence was evident in the tone and content of the message, and its source is the Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY). Thus, the pivot of the strategy is to amplify its message—an inclusive, progressive vision of India where constitutional values reign supreme, standing against what it calls the BJP's politics of division and Hindutva. And a brand of nationalism that, in Rahul's words, can stand up to external foes like China as also fight internal corporate oligarchs the way the party had once fought British colonialism.

The document also ends any ambiguity on the party's position in the Opposition spectrum. "There is an urgent need for a united Opposition to take on the NDA on common ideological grounds," the Congress political resolution reads. "Emergence of any third force will provide advantage to the BJP/NDA." Read this as the party announcing itself as the fulcrum of any anti-BJP alliance and not playing second fiddle to an alternative formation led by another party, be it the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC or the K. Chandrasekhar Rao-led BRS or the Nitish Kumar-led JD(U). The party is clear that it needs to recapture the central space in the current polity to redefine the political discourse.

Invoking the idea of India as "laid down by Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru", the Congress reiterated its commitment to secularism, socialism and federalism to "emerge as a mass- and cadre-based vibrant party". Most of its political resolutions, hence, focused on countering what it calls India's democratic backsliding: strengthening constitutional bodies, ensuring the independence of the judiciary and media, cleaning up the electoral process, protecting the rights and liberties of citizens, rolling out newer programmes for social and economic inclusion of the marginalised and minorities. It intends to bring out a Vision Document for 2024, which will encompass issues of unemployment, poverty, inflation, women's empowerment and national security. Having badly burnt its fingers in the 2019 general election, the Congress is determined that its electoral narrative will steer clear of direct conflict with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and focus instead on everyday and local issues. The idea is to ensure that voters get to know about (and be impressed by) the governance model and welfare policies of Congress-ruled states like